

POLITICAL PARTIES

PARTY AS DEMOCRATIC INTERMEDIARY → SECTION 29A REGISTRATION AND → RECOGNITION AND SYMBOL ARCHITECTURE → PARTY SYSTEM EVOLUTION, REGIONALISATION → INTERNAL DEMOCRACY, MEMBERSHIP, CANDIDATES → FINANCE AND THE ELECTORAL-BONDS

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / ECI REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • active generation g2 repaired in place for answer-line and visual-boundary quality • all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00 PARTY AS DEMOCRATIC INTERMEDIARY, NOT CONSTITUTIONAL SOVEREIGN

PARTY AS DEMOCRATIC INTERMEDIARY, NOT CONSTITUTIONAL SOVEREIGN ROOT QUESTION HOW CAN PARTIES AGGREGATE CITIZENS AND GOVERN WITHOUT BECOMING DEMOCRATIC FUNCTIONS REPRESENTATION PROGRAMME CHOICE GOVERNMENT LEGISLATIVE COORDINATION

LEGAL LOCATION ORIGINAL CONSTITUTION NO COMPREHENSIVE PARTY CODE.

ROOT QUESTION

How can parties aggregate citizens and govern without becoming private constitutional sovereigns?

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE

- ROOT QUESTION
- How can parties aggregate citizens and govern without becoming private constitutional sovereigns?
- DEMOCRATIC FUNCTIONS representation

POWER / PROCEDURE

- programme choice government
- legislative coordination
- LEGAL LOCATION original Constitution: no comprehensive party code.

CHECK / LIMIT

- Tenth Schedule: defection only.
- RPA 1951: registration, contribution and disclosure fields.
- Symbols Order 1968: recognition and symbol disputes.

FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT

- TENSION public democratic power < – Article 19(1)(c) associational autonomy.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The result is segmented regulation: the party is strongly regulated at entry, elections and legislative discipline but weakly regulated in its internal membership, leadership and candidate-selection life.

01 SECTION 29A REGISTRATION AND ECI'S BOUNDED CANCELLATION POWER

SECTION 29A REGISTRATION AND ECI'S BOUNDED CANCELLATION POWER SECTION 29A ASSOCIATION APPLIES TO ECI ALLEGIANCE DECLARATION TO CONSTITUTION, SOCIALISM, SECULARISM, DEMOCRACY, SOVEREIGNTY, UNITY RECOGNITION REGISTRATION CREATES STATUTORY PARTY STATUS

RECOGNITION FOLLOWS SYMBOLS ORDER PERFORMANCE CRITERIA INDIAN NATIONAL CONGRESS V. INSTITUTE OF SOCIAL WELFARE (2002) ECI HAS NO GENERAL REVIEW/DEREGISTRATION POWER NARROW CANCELLATION SURVIVES FOR FRAUD, FOUNDATIONAL DISQUALIFICATION OR ANALOGOUS

SECTION 29A association applies to ECI – memorandum/rules – allegiance declaration to Constitution, socialism, secularism

and integrity.

REGISTRATION != RECOGNITION registration creates statutory party status

recognition follows Symbols Order performance criteria.

Indian National Congress v. Institute of Social Welfare (2002)

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE

- SECTION 29A association applies to ECI – memorandum/rules – allegiance declaration to Constitution, socialism, secularism, democracy, sovereignty, unity
- and integrity.

POWER / PROCEDURE

- REGISTRATION != RECOGNITION registration creates statutory party status
- recognition follows Symbols Order performance criteria.

CHECK / LIMIT

- Indian National Congress v. Institute of Social Welfare (2002)
- ECI has no general review/deregistration power

FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT

- narrow cancellation survives for fraud, foundational disqualification or analogous grounds.
- TRAP loss of recognition: symbol consequence and deregistration are different legal events.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Political-party registration under section 29A differs from recognition under the Symbols Order, making performance rules more durable than any date-sensitive party list.

02 RECOGNITION AND SYMBOL ARCHITECTURE WITHOUT FREEZING PARTY LISTS

RECOGNITION AND SYMBOL ARCHITECTURE WITHOUT FREEZING PARTY LISTS SYMBOLS ORDER 1968 RECOGNISED NATIONAL PARTY RECOGNISED STATE PARTY REGISTERED-UNRECOGNISED PARTY ANY ONE DATED ROUTE 6% VALID VOTES IN FOUR OR MORE STATES

2% LOK SABHA SEATS FROM AT LEAST THREE STATES STATE-PARTY RECOGNITION IN FOUR STATES

SYMBOLS ORDER 1968 recognised National party

recognised State party

registered-unrecognised party.

8% vote route.

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE

- SYMBOLS ORDER 1968 recognised National party
- recognised State party
- registered-unrecognised party
- NATIONAL: ANY ONE DATED ROUTE

POWER / PROCEDURE

- 6% valid votes in four or more States + four Lok Sabha seats
- 2% Lok Sabha seats from at least three States
- State-party recognition in four States.
- STATE: ANY ONE DATED ROUTE vote-plus-seat tests

CHECK / LIMIT

- 3% or three Assembly seats
- Lok Sabha ratio route
- 8% vote route.
- PRIVILEGE reserved symbol and specified electoral facilities.

FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT

- CONTROL: criteria are Order-based and re-verifiable; do not freeze the current party list.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Invalidating electoral bonds restored voter-information principles, but did not itself create donation caps or a complete political-finance disclosure system.

03 PARTY SYSTEM EVOLUTION, REGIONALISATION AND COALITION FEDERALISM

PARTY SYSTEM EVOLUTION, REGIONALISATION AND COALITION FEDERALISM 1952-1967 CONGRESS SYSTEM 1967 FRAGMENTATION 1977 ALTERNATION 1989-2014 COALITION BARGAINING POST-2014 CENTRAL DOMINANCE WITH STRONG STATE-PARTY PLURALITY

PARTY-SYSTEM TYPES ONE-PARTY DOMINANCE TWO-PARTY TENDENCY

1952-1967 Congress system – 1967 fragmentation

1977 alternation – 1989-2014 coalition bargaining

post-2014 central dominance with strong State-party plurality.

PARTY-SYSTEM TYPES one-party dominance

two-party tendency

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE

- 1952-1967 Congress system – 1967 fragmentation
- 1977 alternation – 1989-2014 coalition bargaining
- post-2014 central dominance with strong State-party plurality.

POWER / PROCEDURE

- PARTY-SYSTEM TYPES one-party dominance
- two-party tendency
- multi-party competition

CHECK / LIMIT

- coalition system.
- REGIONAL PARTIES identity representation + State autonomy + policy innovation
- < – personalisation + fragmentation + bargaining cost.

FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT

- 2022 GS-II centralisation/autonomy preference follows organisational position and power incentives, not a permanent ideological law.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: India's party system moved from Congress dominance through coalition fragmentation to renewed centralisation, showing how organisational form shifts the federal balance of political power.

04 INTERNAL DEMOCRACY, MEMBERSHIP, CANDIDATES AND DYNASTIC CONTROL

INTERNAL DEMOCRACY, MEMBERSHIP, CANDIDATES AND DYNASTIC CONTROL MEMBERSHIP PUBLISHED ELIGIBILITY RELIABLE ROLL NOTICE/HEARING FOR DISCIPLINE LEADERSHIP PERIODIC ELECTION REAL COMPETITION TRANSPARENT COUNTING STATE-UNIT VOICE.

MEMBERSHIP published eligibility – reliable roll – notice/hearing for discipline – appeal.

LEADERSHIP periodic election – real competition – transparent counting – State-unit voice.

CANDIDATES local consultation + published criteria + integrity + representativeness

< – dynasty + money + winnability + central nomination.

CURRENT GAP

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE

- MEMBERSHIP published eligibility – reliable roll – notice/hearing for discipline – appeal.
- LEADERSHIP periodic election – real competition – transparent counting – State-unit voice.

POWER / PROCEDURE

- CANDIDATES local consultation + published criteria + integrity + representativeness
- < – dynasty + money + winnability + central nomination.

CHECK / LIMIT

- CURRENT GAP
- ECI receives organisational particulars but no comprehensive statutory internal-democracy code exists.

FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT

- REFORM LIMIT minimum process safeguards must not authorise State selection of ideology or leaders.
- MEMBERSHIP published eligibility – reliable roll – notice/hearing for discipline – appeal.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Regionalisation widened representation and made federalism a lived bargain, but it also fragmented mandates and increased the coordination costs of national decision-making.

05 FINANCE AND THE ELECTORAL-BONDS CONSTITUTIONAL RESET

FINANCE AND THE ELECTORAL-BONDS CONSTITUTIONAL RESET PARTY FINANCE CHANNELS INDIVIDUAL/CORPORATE CONTRIBUTION ELECTORAL TRUST CASH WITHIN LAW PUBLIC FACILITIES RPA SECTION 29C AND TAX/COMPANY-LAW RULES OPERATE THROUGH SEPARATE

ASSOCIATION FOR DEMOCRATIC REFORMS V. UNION OF INDIA (2024) ELECTORAL BOND SCHEME AND ENABLING ANONYMITY CHANGES STRUCK DOWN

PARTY FINANCE CHANNELS individual/corporate contribution

electoral trust

cash within law

public facilities.

RPA Section 29C and tax/company-law rules operate through separate thresholds and filings.

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE

- PARTY FINANCE CHANNELS individual/corporate contribution
- electoral trust
- cash within law

POWER / PROCEDURE

- public facilities.
- RPA Section 29C and tax/company-law rules operate through separate thresholds and filings.
- Association for Democratic Reforms v. Union of India (2024)

CHECK / LIMIT

- Electoral Bond Scheme and enabling anonymity changes struck down
- voter's Article 19(1)(a) right to information protected
- SBI disclosure to ECI ordered.

FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT

- LIMIT judgment did not create full State funding, ban every corporate donation or enact a complete campaign-finance code.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Regionalisation has widened representation and made federalism a lived bargain, but it has also fragmented mandates and raised the transaction costs of national decision-making – a democratisation with a coordination price.

06 WHIPS, ANTI-DEFECTION AND PARTY-SYMBOL IDENTITY

WHIPS, ANTI-DEFECTION AND PARTY-SYMBOL IDENTITY PARTY ORGANISATION MEMBERSHIP, LEADERSHIP AND CANDIDATE SELECTION. LEGISLATURE PARTY MEMBERS OF THE HOUSE BELONGING TO THE TENTH SCHEDULE VOLUNTARY GIVING UP VOTE/ABSTENTION DIRECTION PRESIDING-OFFICER DECISION.

SYMBOLS ORDER ECI DECIDES RIVAL-FACTION SYMBOL/RECOGNITION QUESTIONS.

PARTY ORGANISATION membership, leadership and candidate selection.

LEGISLATURE PARTY members of the House belonging to the political party.

TENTH SCHEDULE voluntary giving up

vote/abstention direction

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE

- PARTY ORGANISATION membership, leadership and candidate selection.
- LEGISLATURE PARTY members of the House belonging to the political party.
- TENTH SCHEDULE voluntary giving up

POWER / PROCEDURE

- vote/abstention direction
- presiding-officer decision.
- SYMBOLS ORDER

CHECK / LIMIT

- ECI decides rival-faction symbol/recognition questions.
- Sadiq Ali v. Election Commission of India (1972) majority in organisational and legislative wings informs symbol identity.
- TRAP symbol dispute, internal leadership, whip authorisation and defection are related but legally separate proceedings.

FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT

- vote/abstention direction

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A defensible party-system analysis links statutory rules and case law to one central tension—representation through organised competition versus opacity within party organisations.

07 CRIMINALISATION, DISCLOSURE AND NOTA LIMITS

CRIMINALISATION, DISCLOSURE AND NOTA LIMITS UNION OF INDIA V. ASSOCIATION FOR DEMOCRATIC REFORMS (2002) CRIMINAL, FINANCIAL AND EDUCATIONAL DISCLOSURE INFORMED VOTER. LILY THOMAS V. UNION OF INDIA (2013) RPA SECTION 8(4) SITTING-MEMBER SHIELD REMOVED

DISQUALIFICATION STILL FOLLOWS CONVICTION, NOT ACCUSATION ALONE. RAMBABU SINGH THAKUR V. SUNIL ARORA (2020) PARTY PUBLICATION

Union of India v.

Association for Democratic Reforms (2002) + PUCL (2003) candidate affidavit – criminal, financial and educational

Lily Thomas v. Union of India (2013)

RPA Section 8(4) sitting-member shield removed

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE

- Union of India v.
- Association for Democratic Reforms (2002) + PUCL (2003) candidate affidavit – criminal, financial and educational disclosure – informed voter.

POWER / PROCEDURE

- Lily Thomas v. Union of India (2013)
- RPA Section 8(4) sitting-member shield removed

CHECK / LIMIT

- disqualification still follows conviction, not accusation alone.
- Rambabu Singh Thakur v. Sunil Arora (2020) party publication of criminal antecedents and selection reasons.

FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT

- PEOPLE'S UNION FOR CIVIL LIBERTIES (2013) negative secret choice recognised.
- NOTA does not automatically cancel the poll, disqualify all candidates or trigger re-election.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Candidate disclosure exposes criminal antecedents, but party incentives centred on winnability limit its effect unless selection practices and disqualification law also change.

08 UPSC SYNTHESIS: REGULATE DEMOCRATIC POWER WITHOUT NATIONALISING ASSOCIATION

UPSC SYNTHESIS REGULATE DEMOCRATIC POWER WITHOUT NATIONALISING ASSOCIATION PRELIMS FIREWALL 29A REGISTRATION FREE SYMBOL RECOGNITION LOSS LEGISLATURE PARTY BONDS VERDICT FINANCE CODE.

PRELIMS FIREWALL

29A registration != recognition

reserved != free symbol recognition loss != deregistration

disclosure != disqualification

NOTA != re-poll

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS / ARTICLE

- PRELIMS FIREWALL
- 29A registration != recognition
- reserved != free symbol recognition loss != deregistration
- disclosure != disqualification

POWER / PROCEDURE

- NOTA != re-poll
- party != legislature party
- bonds verdict != finance code.
- MAINS SPINE democratic role – segmented legal basis – party-system evolution

CHECK / LIMIT

- internal democracy – finance – criminalisation – whip/symbol interfaces
- autonomy-transparency balance – reform.
- REFORM PACKAGE verified internal elections
- candidate criteria

FEDERAL / RIGHTS IMPACT

- donation transparency independent audit
- trial expedition
- narrow deregistration amendment proportionate ECI power + judicial review.
- VERDICT regulate the party's public consequences while preserving its legitimate associational core.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Party registration is statutory and anti-defection rules regulate legislative loyalty, but neither creates comprehensive constitutional control over internal democracy or finance.

E SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT PART A — FEATURES OF THE INDIAN PARTY SYSTEM PART B — RECOGNITION NATIONAL VS STATE PARTIES MULTI-PARTY SYSTEM — INDIA HAS THE LARGEST NUMBER OF ONE-DOMINANT-PARTY SYSTEM — RAJNI KOTHARI'S "CONGRESS SYSTEM" (DECLINED POST-1967).

LACK OF CLEAR IDEOLOGY (EXCEPT BJP, CPI, CPM); PERSONALITY EMERGENCE OF REGIONAL PARTIES; FACTIONS & DEFECTIONS

OPTIONAL DOCTRINE / CASE

• PART A — FEATURES OF THE INDIAN PARTY SYSTEM

• PART B — RECOGNITION: NATIONAL VS STATE PARTIES

• Multi-party system — India has the largest number of parties in the world.

• One-dominant-party system — Rajni Kothari's "Congress system" (declined post-1967).

ADVANCED LIMIT

• Lack of clear ideology (except BJP, CPI, CPM); personality cult; parties based on religion/caste/language.

• Emergence of regional parties; factions & defections; lack of an effective Opposition.

• Reserved symbol; one proposer for nomination; broadcast time on state media; access to electoral rolls.

• Star campaigners: recognised = 40, registered-unrecognised = 20 (their travel not counted in candidate expenditure).

COMPARATIVE NUANCE

• NOT: Parties are registered under the Constitution – registered under Sec 29A, RPA 1951 (a statute).

• NOT: National-party status needs 6% votes in all states – 6% in any 4+ states + 4 LS seats (or the alternatives).

• NOT: Recognised & unrecognised parties get the same star campaigners – 40 vs 20.

• NOT: A "national party" contests only national elections – the label is about recognition/privileges, not where it contests.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.